League, later a Liberal, and the holder of high office in the Government of India and the Madras Government.

In accordance with the Congress policy, following Gandhiji's advice, not a word was said in public about this unprovoked attack on the Congress in normal times by the Travancore Government.[1] Some of the Liberals even protested against it vigorously. Indeed, Gandhiji's position in regard to the States is far more moderate and restrained than that of the Liberals. Perhaps among the leading public men only Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya, with his close contacts with numerous Princes, is equally restrained and solicitous of not offending the susceptibilities of the Rulers.

Gandhiji was not always so cautious in regard to the Indian Princes. On a famous occasion in February 1916, during the inauguration ceremonies of the Hindu University at Benares, he addressed a meeting presided over by one of the Princes and attended by a host of other Princes. He had freshly returned from South Africa, and the burden of all-India politics was not yet on his shoulders. Earnestly and with a prophet's fire he addressed them and told them to mend their ways and give up their vain pomp and luxury. "Princes! Go and sell your jewels!" he said; and though they may not have sold their jewels, they certainly went. In great consternation, one by one and in small groups, they left the hall, and even the president trooped out, leaving the speaker to carry on by himself. Mrs. Annie Besant, who was present then, was also offended at Gandhiji's remarks and withdrew from the meeting.

In his letter to Mr. N. C. Kelkar, Gandhiji says further: "I would like the States to grant autonomy to their subjects, and would like the Princes to regard themselves and be, in fact, trustees for the people over whom they rule. . . ." If there is anything in this idea of trusteeship, why should we object to the claim of the British Government that they are trustees for the Government of India? Except for the fact that they are foreigners in India, I see no difference. There are almost equally marked differences as regards the colour of the skin, racial origin and culture between various peoples in India.

[1] Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel laid stress on this non-intervention policy in a speech at Baroda on January 6th, 1935. He is reported to have said "that workers in Indian States should do their work with all the limitations imposed by the State, and instead of criticising the administration, efforts should be made to keep up cordial relations between the ruler and the ruled."